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AI



72% of US teens have
used AI companions,
study finds

Hopefully not Grok's companions ...

A new study by a U.S. nonprofit focused on the lives of kids and families, Common Sense Media, has found that a vast majority of U.S. teens (72%) have tried an AI companion at least once. By “companion,” the study is focused on AI chatbots that are designed for users to have more personal conversations with, not AI assistants that work as homework helpers, image generators, or voice assistants that just answer questions.

For instance, the study’s definition of AI companions could include those digital AI personas provided by companies like Character.AI or Replika, but it could also encompass the use of general-purpose chatbots like ChatGPT or Claude, which can be used for more personal conversations, if desired.

The study found that chatting with an AI seems to be appealing to U.S. teens (ages 13 to 17), as not only had nearly three-quarters tried an AI companion, but also 52% said they are regular users. Among those who engaged with these companions regularly, 13% chat with them daily and 21% chat a few times a week.

Boys (31%) were also slightly more likely than girls (25%) to say they had never used an AI companion, among the one in four teens who said they have never tried it.

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The findings are based on a [study](#) that ran during April and May 2025 and used a representative sample of 1,060 teens and was conducted by researchers from NORC at the University of Chicago. There have already been concerns about AI's impact on teens' well-being, as one firm, Character.AI, is being sued over [a teen's suicide](#) in Florida and for [promoting violence](#) in Texas. There are also a number of reports that describe the [potential dangers](#) of using AI for therapy.

The findings from Common Sense Media's new study offer an early understanding of how young people are using AI to simulate human interactions, which could include virtual friendship, emotional support, therapy, and role-playing games, among other things.

The analysis also examined other behaviors around teen usage of AI companions, including what sorts of tasks teens turned to them for, why, and what the after-effects were.

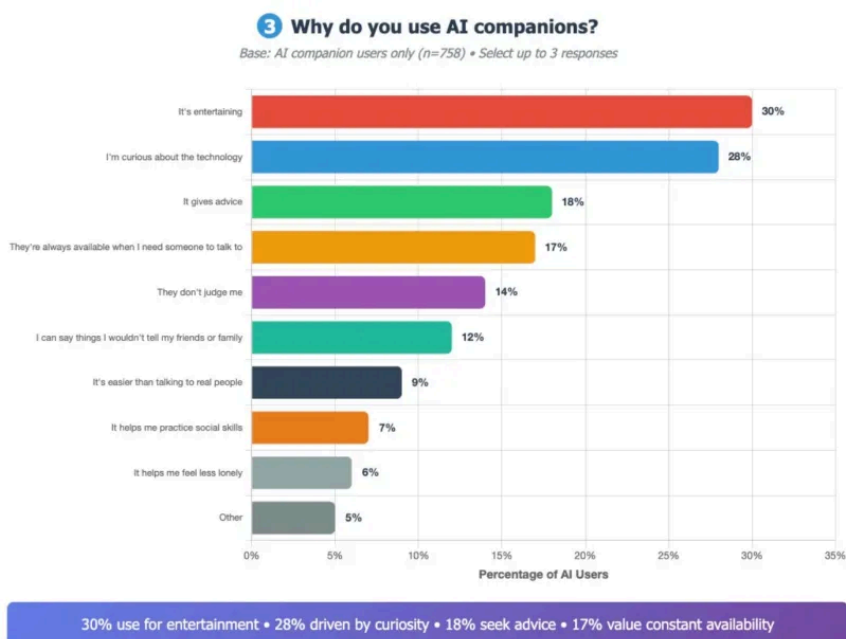


IMAGE CREDITS: COMMON SENSE MEDIA

For instance, nearly half (46%) said they saw AI companions as tools or programs, and 33% said they use them for social interaction and relationships. Teens said they use the AI companions for various purposes: entertainment

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(30%), curiosity about AI technology (28%), advice (18%), and because they're always available (17%).

Half of teens (50%) said they don't trust the information provided by AI companions. However, older teens are less likely to trust the AI's advice compared with younger teens, ages 13 to 14, at 20% and 27%, respectively.

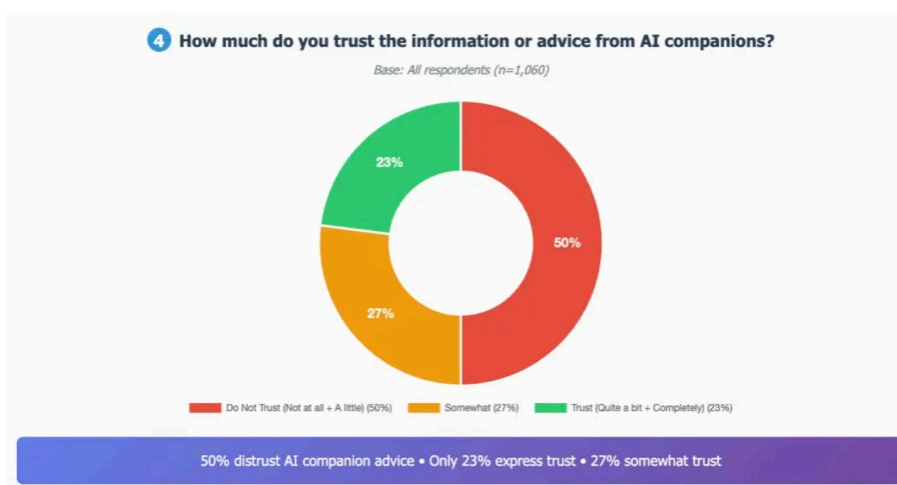


IMAGE CREDITS:COMMON SENSE MEDIA

One-third of the teens said they find the conversations more satisfying than those with real-life friends, though the majority (67%) felt the opposite way.

Plus, 39% were using the AI conversations as practice for real-life interactions, as 39% said they applied skills they first tried with an AI to real-world situations. Among the skills practiced, social skills were the top use case, with 39% of teens having explored this area, followed by conversation starters (18%), giving advice (14%), and expressing emotions (13%).

6 Have you used any of the following skills you've practiced with AI companions in real-life situations?

Base: AI companion users only (n=758) • Multiple responses allowed

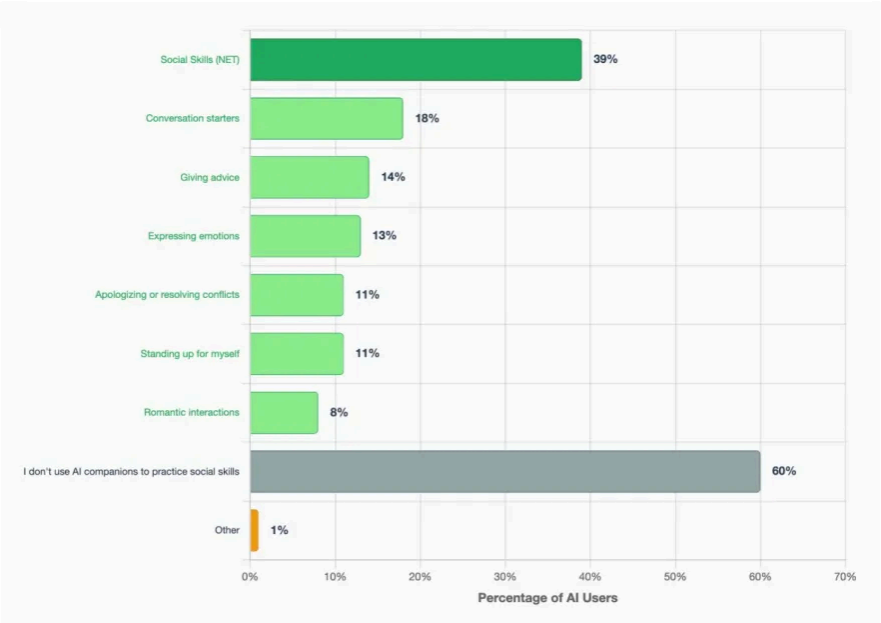


IMAGE CREDITS:COMMON SENSE MEDIA

In terms of whether real-life relationships will be replaced by tech, there was one positive finding: 80% of teens who used AI companions said they spend more time with real friends than with their AI chatbots. Only 6% said the reverse was true.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🦋](#) [m](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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AI



OpenAI partners with Common Sense Media to collaborate on AI guidelines

Kyle Wiggers — 12:32 PM PST · January 29, 2024

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

OpenAI hopes to win the trust of parents — and policymakers — by partnering with organizations that work to minimize tech and media harms to kids, preteens and teens.

Case in point, OpenAI today announced a partnership with Common Sense Media, the nonprofit organization that reviews and ranks the suitability of various media and tech for kids, to collaborate on AI guidelines and education materials for parents, educators and young adults.

As a part of the partnership, OpenAI will work with Common Sense Media to curate “family-friendly”

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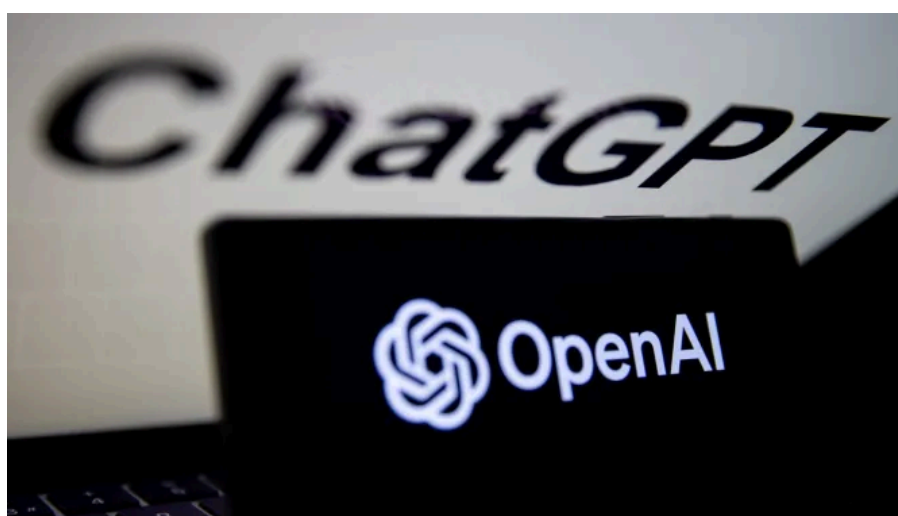


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GPTs — chatbot apps powered by OpenAI’s GenAI models — in the [GPT Store](#), OpenAI’s GPT marketplace, based on Common Sense’s rating and evaluation standards, OpenAI CEO Sam Altman says.

“AI offers incredible benefits for families and teens, and our partnership with Common Sense will further strengthen our safety work, ensuring that families and teens can use our tools with confidence,” Altman added in a canned statement.

The launch of the partnership comes after OpenAI said that it would participate in Common Sense’s new framework, launched in September, for ratings and reviews designed to assess the safety, transparency, ethical use and impact of AI products. Common Sense’s framework aims to produce a “nutrition label” for AI-powered apps, according to Common Sense co-founder and CEO James Steyer, toward shedding light on the contexts in which the apps are used and highlight areas of potential opportunity and harm against a set of “common sense” tenets.



THE OPENAI LOGO DISPLAYED ON A SMARTPHONE SCREEN IN FRONT OF COMPUTER SCREEN WITH THE CHATGPT LOGO.

IMAGE CREDITS: DIDEM MENTE/ANADOLU AGENCY / GETTY IMAGES

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educate families and educators about safe, responsible use of [OpenAI tools like] ChatGPT, so that we can collectively avoid any unintended consequences of this emerging technology.”

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OpenAI's under pressure from regulators to show that its GenAI-powered apps, including ChatGPT, are an overall boon for society — not a detriment to it. Just last summer, the U.S. Federal Trade Commission opened an investigation into OpenAI over whether ChatGPT harmed consumers through its collection of data and publication of false statements on individuals. European data authorities have also [expressed concern](#) over OpenAI's private information handling.

OpenAI's tools, like all GenAI tools, tend to confidently [make things up](#) and [get basic facts wrong](#). And they're [biased](#) — a reflection of the data that was used to train them.

Kids and teens, aware of the tools' limitations or no, are increasingly turning to them for help not only with schoolwork but personal issues. According to a [poll](#) from the Center for Democracy and Technology, 29% of kids report having used ChatGPT to deal with anxiety or mental health issues, 22% for issues with friends and 16% for family conflicts.

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Kyle Wiggers

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Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch's AI Editor until June 2025. His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital Trend...



IMAGE CREDITS: [OS TARTAROUCHOS](#)
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AI



Several popular AI products flagged as unsafe for kids by Common Sense Media

Sarah Perez — 8:06 AM PST · November 16, 2023

An independent review of popular AI tools has found that many — including Snapchat’s My AI, DALLE, and Stable Diffusion, may not be safe for kids. The new reviews come from [Common Sense Media](#), a nonprofit advocacy group for families that’s best known for providing [media ratings for parents](#) who want to evaluate the apps, games, podcasts, TV shows, movies, and books their children are consuming. Earlier this year, the [company said](#) it

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would soon add ratings for AI products to its resources for families. Today, [those ratings have gone live](#), offering so-called “nutrition labels” for AI products, like chatbots, image generators, and more.

The company first announced in July that it aimed to build a ratings system to assess AI products across a number of dimensions, including whether or not the technology takes advantage of responsible AI practices as well as its suitability for children. The move was triggered by a survey of parents to gauge their interest in such a service. 82% of parents said they wanted help in evaluating whether or not new AI products, like ChatGPT, were safe for their kids to use. Only 40% said they knew of any reliable resources that would help them to make those determinations.

That led to today’s launch of Common Sense Media’s [first AI product ratings](#). The products it assesses are ratings across [several AI principles](#), including trust, kids’ safety, privacy, transparency, accountability, learning, fairness, social connections, and benefits to people and society.

The organization initially reviewed 10 popular apps on a 5-point scale, including those used for learning, AI chatbots like Bard and ChatGPT, as well as generative AI products, like Snap’s My AI and DALL-E and others. Not surprisingly, the latter category fared the worst.

“AI is not always correct, nor is it values-neutral,” remarked Tracy Pizzo-Frey, Senior Advisor of AI at Common Sense Media, [in a summary of the ratings](#). “All generative AI, by virtue of the fact that the models are trained on massive amounts of internet data, host a wide variety of cultural, racial, socioeconomic, historical, and gender biases – and that is exactly what we found in our evaluations,” she said. “We hope our ratings will encourage more

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developers to build protections that limit misinformation from spreading and do their part to shield future generations from unintended repercussions.”

In TechCrunch’s own tests, reporter Amanda Silberling found [Snapchat’s My AI generative AI features generally tended to be more weird and random](#), than actively harmful, but Common Sense Media [gave the AI chatbot a 2-star rating](#), noting that it produced some responses that reinforced unfair biases around ageism, sexism, and cultural stereotypes. It also offers some inappropriate responses, at times, as well as inaccuracies. It also stored personal user data, which the organization said raised privacy concerns.

Snap pushed back at the poor review, noting that My AI was an optional tool and that Snapchat makes it clear it’s a chatbot and advises users about its limitations.

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“By default, My AI displays a robot emoji. Before anyone can interact with My AI, we show an in-app message to make clear it's a chatbot and advise on its limitations,” said Snap spokesperson, Maggie Cherneff. “My AI is also integrated into our Family Center so parents can see if and when teens are chatting with it. We appreciate the feedback in the review as we continue to improve our product,” she added.

Other generative AI models like [DALL-E](#) and [Stable Diffusion](#) had similar risks, including a tendency toward objectification and sexualization of women and girls and a reinforcement of gender stereotypes, among other concerns.

Like any new medium on the internet, these generative AI models are also [being used to produce pornographic materials](#). Sites like [Hugging Face](#) and [Civitai](#) have grown popular not only as resources for finding new image models, but also making it easier to find different models that can be combined with one another to make porn using someone's (like a celeb's) likeness. That issue came to a head this week, as [404Media](#) called out Civitai's capabilities, but the debate as to the responsible party — the community aggregators or the AI models itself — continued [on sites like Hacker News in the aftermath](#).

In the mid-tier of Common Sense's ratings, were AI chatbots like Google's [Bard](#) (which just yesterday [officially opened to teens](#)), [ChatGPT](#), and [Toddle AI](#).

The organization warned that bias may occur in these bots as well, particularly for users with “diverse backgrounds and dialects.” They could also produce inaccurate information — or AI hallucinations — and reinforce stereotypes. Common Sense warned that the false information AI produces could shape users’ worldviews and make it even more difficult to separate fact from fiction.

OpenAI responded to the new rankings by noting the age requirements it has for users.

“We care deeply about the safety and privacy of everyone who uses our tools, including young people, which is why we’ve built strong guardrails and safety measures into ChatGPT and let users choose when their conversations are used to improve our models,” said OpenAI spokesperson Kayla Wood. “We require users ages 13-17 to have parental consent to use our tools, and do not allow children younger than 13 to use our services,” she noted.

The only AI products to receive good reviews were [Ello’s](#) AI reading tutor and book delivery service, [Khanmingo](#) (from Khan Academy), and [Kyron Learning’s](#) AI tutor — all three being AI products designed for educational purposes. They’re less well-known than others. (And, as some kids may argue, less fun). Still, because the companies designed them with kids’ usage in mind, they tended to use responsible AI practices and focused on fairness, diverse representation, and kid-friendly design considerations. They also were more transparent about their data privacy policies.

Common Sense Media says it will continue to publish ratings and reviews of new AI products on a rolling basis, which it hopes will help to inform not only parents and families, but also lawmakers and regulators.

“Consumers must have access to a clear nutrition label for AI products that could compromise the safety and privacy of all Americans—but especially children and teens,” said James P. Steyer, founder and CEO of Common Sense Media, in a statement. “By learning what the product is, how it works, its ethical risks, limitations, and misuses, lawmakers, educators, and the general public can understand what responsible AI looks like. If the government fails to ‘childproof’ AI, tech companies will take advantage of this unregulated, freewheeling atmosphere at the expense of our data privacy, well-being, and democracy at large,” he added.

Updated, 11/16/23, 4:18 PM ET with OpenAI comment.

[Google is opening up its Bard AI chatbot to teenagers](#)

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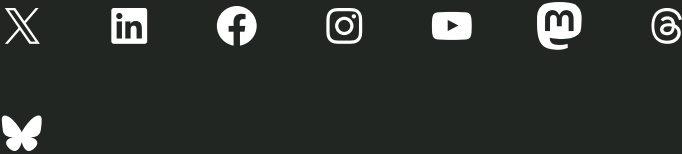
Sarah Perez

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